Cambridge Assessment International Education

Cambridge O Level

ENGLISH LANGUAGE **1123/12**

Paper 1 Writing **October/November 2023**

MARK SCHEME

Maximum Mark: 60

Published

This mark scheme is published as an aid to teachers and candidates, to indicate the requirements of the examination. It shows the basis on which Examiners were instructed to award marks. It does not indicate the details of the discussions that took place at an Examiners' meeting before marking began, which would have considered the acceptability of alternative answers.

Mark schemes should be read in conjunction with the question paper and the Principal Examiner Report for Teachers.

Cambridge International will not enter into discussions about these mark schemes.

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Generic Marking Principles

These general marking principles must be applied by all examiners when marking candidate answers. They should be applied alongside the specific content of the mark scheme or generic level descriptors for a question. Each question paper and mark scheme will also comply with these marking principles.

GENERIC MARKING PRINCIPLE 1:

Marks must be awarded in line with:

- the specific content of the mark scheme or the generic level descriptors for the question
- the specific skills defined in the mark scheme or in the generic level descriptors for the question
- the standard of response required by a candidate as exemplified by the standardisation scripts.

GENERIC MARKING PRINCIPLE 2:

Marks awarded are always **whole marks** (not half marks, or other fractions).

GENERIC MARKING PRINCIPLE 3:

Marks must be awarded **positively**:

- marks are awarded for correct/valid answers, as defined in the mark scheme. However, credit is given for valid answers which go beyond the scope of the syllabus and mark scheme, referring to your Team Leader as appropriate
- marks are awarded when candidates clearly demonstrate what they know and can do
- marks are not deducted for errors
- marks are not deducted for omissions
- answers should only be judged on the quality of spelling, punctuation and grammar when these features are specifically assessed by the question as indicated by the mark scheme. The meaning, however, should be unambiguous.

GENERIC MARKING PRINCIPLE 4:

Rules must be applied consistently, e.g. in situations where candidates have not followed instructions or in the application of generic level descriptors.

GENERIC MARKING PRINCIPLE 5:

Marks should be awarded using the full range of marks defined in the mark scheme for the question (however; the use of the full mark range may be limited according to the quality of the candidate responses seen).

GENERIC MARKING PRINCIPLE 6:

Marks awarded are based solely on the requirements as defined in the mark scheme. Marks should not be awarded with grade thresholds or grade descriptors in mind.

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English & Media subject specific general marking principles
(To be read in conjunction with the Generic Marking Principles (and requiring further guidance on how to place marks within levels))

Components using level descriptors:

- We use level descriptors as a guide to broad understanding of the qualities normally expected of, or typical of, work in a level.
- Level descriptors are a means of general guidance, and should not be interpreted as hurdle statements.
- Where indicative content notes are supplied for a question, these are *not* a prescription of required content, and must not be treated as such. Alternative correct points and unexpected answers in candidates' scripts must be given marks that fairly reflect the knowledge and skills demonstrated.
- While we may have legitimate expectations as to the ground most answers may occupy, we must at all times be prepared to meet candidates on their chosen ground, provided it is relevant ground (e.g. clearly related to and derived from a relevant passage/text and meeting the mark scheme requirements for the question).

Components using point-based marking:

Point marking is often used to reward knowledge, understanding and application of skills. We give credit where the candidate's answer shows relevant knowledge, understanding and application of skills in answering the question. We do not give credit where the answer shows confusion.

From this it follows that we:

a DO credit answers which are worded differently from the mark scheme if they clearly convey the same meaning (unless the mark scheme requires a specific term).

b DO credit alternative answers/examples which are not written in the mark scheme if they are correct.

c DO credit answers where candidates give more than one correct answer in one prompt/numbered/scaffolded space where extended writing is required rather than list-type answers. For example, questions that require *n* reasons (e.g. State two reasons…).

d DO NOT credit answers simply for using a 'key term' unless that is all that is required. (Check for evidence it is understood and not used wrongly.).

e DO NOT credit answers which are obviously self-contradicting or trying to cover all possibilities.

f DO NOT give further credit for what is effectively repetition of a correct point already credited unless the language itself is being tested. This applies equally to 'mirror statements' (i.e. polluted/not polluted).

g DO NOT require spellings to be correct, unless this is part of the test. However spellings of syllabus terms must allow for clear and unambiguous separation from other syllabus terms with which they may be confused (e.g. Corrasion/Corrosion).

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The assessment objectives for Sections 1 and 2 are:

Assessment Objectives for Writing **(AO1)**

W1	Articulate experience and express what is thought, felt and imagined
W2	Sequence facts, ideas and opinions
W3	Use a range of appropriate vocabulary
W4	Use register appropriate to audience and context
W5	Make accurate use of spelling, punctuation and grammar

Assessment Objectives for Reading **(AO2)**

R1	Demonstrate understanding of explicit meanings
R2	Demonstrate understanding of implicit meanings and attitudes

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Section 1 Question

You spent part of your recent long vacation at an adventure camp, doing a wide range of activities with lots of other young people. You really liked some aspects of your stay at the camp but disliked others. Your English teacher has now asked you to make a speech to your class about your stay at the camp.

*Write your **speech**. You must include the following:*

- *where the camp was and how long you were there for*
- *how staying at the camp benefited you*
- *what you disliked about the camp **and** why.*

*Cover all three points above **in detail**. You should make your speech interesting and informative. Start your speech 'Good morning, everyone.'*

Section 2 Questions
Candidates are advised to write between 350 and 500 words.

Description

2. *Describe a typical lunch break at your school. Remember you are describing what people are doing (such as chatting to friends, playing sport or eating), where these activities are taking place, and the atmosphere.*

Argument

3. *'The benefits of healthy eating are now so well understood that no one has any excuse to eat an unhealthy diet.' Do you agree? Give reasons and examples to support your view.*

4. *'It is better to have one or two really close friends than lots of different friends.' What is your opinion? Give reasons and details to support your view.*

Narrative

5. *Write a story which includes the sentence: 'Even though the weather was bad and their clothes were unsuitable, they knew they had to go.'*

6. *Write a story in which a lost phone plays an important part.*

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Section 1 Task Fulfilment 15 marks		
Band 5	**13–15**	• **Very good** understanding of purpose. • **Clear** awareness of the specified situation and audience. • Text type **entirely** appropriate. • **All** required points developed **in detail**, fully amplified and well organised. • Given information **well used** to justify personal opinion and interpretation. • Tone and register **entirely** appropriate.
Band 4	**10–12**	• **Good** understanding of purpose. • **An** awareness of the specified situation and audience. • Text type **appropriate**. • **All** required points addressed **not always** developed in detail. • Given information organised to **support** personal opinion. • Tone and register **appropriate**.
Band 3	**7–9**	• **Some understanding** of purpose. • **Some awareness** of the specified situation and audience. • Text type **generally** appropriate. • **At least two** required points addressed (both partially/fully developed). • Given information may **not be logically organised** to support opinion. • Tone **usually** appropriate although there may be slips of register.
Band 2	**4–6**	• Only **partial understanding** of purpose. • **Some confusion** as to the specified situation and audience. • Text type **may be inappropriate**. • **At least one** required point addressed (partially/fully developed). • Given information **may be used irrelevantly**. • Tone and register **may be uneven**.
Band 1	**1–3**	• **Misunderstanding** of purpose. • **Confusion** as to the specified situation and audience. • **Little evidence** of the specified text type. • **None** of the required points addressed. • Given information **misunderstood** or **irrelevant**. • Tone **may be inappropriate**.
Band 0	**0**	• Insufficient to meet the criteria for Band 1.

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Section 1 Language 15 marks		
Band 8	**14–15**	**Highly accurate writing, apart from very occasional slips.** • Sentence structures **varied for particular effects**. • Verb forms **largely correct** and **appropriate tenses consistently used**. • Vocabulary **wide** and **precise**. • Punctuation **accurate** and **helpful**. • Spelling **accurate**, apart from very occasional slips. • Paragraphs have **unity**, are **linked**, and show **evidence of planning**.
Band 7	**12–13**	**Accurate writing; occasional errors are either slips or caused by ambition.** • Sentence structures show **some variation** to create **some natural fluency**. • **Occasional slips** in verb forms or tense formation, but **sequence consistent** and **clear** throughout. • Vocabulary **precise enough to convey intended shades of meaning**. • Punctuation **accurate** and **generally helpful**. • Spelling **nearly always accurate**. • Paragraphs have **unity**, are **usually linked**, and show **some evidence of planning.**

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Section 1 Language 15 marks		
Band 6	**10–11**	**Mostly accurate writing; errors from ambition do not mar clarity of communication.** • **Some variety** of sentence structures, but a tendency to repeat sentence types may produce a monotonous effect. • Errors may occur in irregular verb forms, but **control of tense sequence sufficient** to sustain clear progression of events or ideas. • **Simple** vocabulary **mainly correct**; errors may occur with more ambitious words. • Punctuation **generally accurate** and **sentence separation correctly marked**, but errors may occur, e.g. with direct speech. • Spelling of **simple vocabulary accurate**; some errors in more ambitious words. • Paragraphs may show **some unity**, although links may be absent or inappropriate.
Band 5	**8–9**	**Writing is sufficiently accurate to communicate meaning, with patches of clear, accurate language.** • **Some variety** of sentence **length** and **structure**, not always for particular purpose. • **Errors** in verb forms and tense consistency **may cause uncertainty in sequence of events** or disturb ease of communication. • Vocabulary **usually adequate to convey intended meaning**; idiom may be uncertain. • Punctuation **used** but not always helpful; **occasional sentence separation errors.** • Spelling of **simple vocabulary accurate**; errors in more difficult words. • Paragraphs **used** but may lack unity or coherence.

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Section 1 Language 15 marks		
Band 4	**6–7**	**Overall meaning never in doubt, but errors sufficiently frequent and serious to hamper precision and distract reader from content.** • **Some simple sentence structures accurate**, but unlikely to sustain accuracy for long. • **Errors** in verb forms and tenses will **sometimes confuse sequence of events**. • Vocabulary **limited**, either too simple or imperfectly understood; some idiomatic errors likely. • **Simple** punctuation **usually accurate**, but there may be frequent sentence separation errors. • Spelling of **simple vocabulary accurate**; **frequent errors** in more difficult words. • Paragraphs **used haphazardly**.
Band 3	**4–5**	**The writing has many serious errors of various kinds of 'single-word' type (i.e. they could be corrected without re-writing the sentence); communication established, although weight of error may cause some 'blurring'.** • Sentences probably **simple** and **repetitive** in structure. • Frequent errors in verb forms and haphazard changes of tense **confuse meaning.** • Vocabulary **conveys meaning** but likely to be **simple** and **imprecise**; significant idiomatic errors. • Spelling **may be inconsistent**. • Punctuation and paragraphing **may be haphazard** or non-existent.
Band 2	**2–3**	**Sense usually decipherable but some errors will be 'multiple' (i.e. requiring the reader to re-read and re-organise); meaning may be partly hidden by density of linguistic error.** • Unlikely to be more than **a few accurate sentences**, however simple, in the whole essay.
Band 1	**1**	**Scripts almost entirely or entirely impossible to recognise as pieces of English writing; whole sections make no sense at all.** • Where **occasional patches of relative clarity** are evident, 1 mark should be given.
Band 0	**0**	• Insufficient to meet the criteria for Band 1.

Section 2 Language 30 marks		
Band 8	**27–30**	**Highly accurate writing, apart from very occasional slips.** • Sentence structures **varied for particular effects**. • Verb forms **largely correct** and **appropriate tenses consistently used**. • Vocabulary **wide** and **precise**. • Punctuation **accurate** and **helpful**. • Spelling **accurate**, apart from very occasional slips. • Paragraphs have **unity**, are **linked**, and show **evidence of planning**. **Appropriateness and Content** • **Consistently relevant.** Interest aroused and sustained. • Tone and register **entirely appropriate**. • Descriptions have well-developed images helping to create complex atmosphere • Arguments are well developed, logical, even complex. • Narratives are complex, sophisticated, possibly tense, and may contain devices such as flashbacks.

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Section 2 Language 30 marks		
Band 7	**23–26**	**Accurate writing; occasional errors are either slips or caused by ambition.** • Sentence structures show **some variation** to create **some natural fluency**. • **Occasional slips** in verb forms or tense formation, but **sequence consistent** and **clear** throughout. • Vocabulary **precise enough to convey intended shades of meaning**. • Punctuation **accurate** and **generally helpful**. • Spelling **nearly always accurate**. • Paragraphs have **unity**, are **usually linked**, and show **some evidence of planning.** **Appropriateness and Content** • **Relevant**. Interest aroused and mostly sustained. • Tone and register **appropriate**. • Descriptions have interesting images and a range of detail, helping to create effective atmosphere • Arguments have clearly defined, cohesive, logical stages in their development • Narratives have effective detail creating character or setting, and may contain some sense of climax.

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Section 2 Language 30 marks		
Band 6	**19–22**	**Mostly accurate writing; errors from ambition do not mar clarity of communication.** • **Some variety** of sentence structures, but a tendency to repeat sentence types may produce a monotonous effect. • Errors may occur in irregular verb forms, but **control of tense sequence sufficient** to sustain clear progression of events or ideas. • **Simple** vocabulary **mainly correct**; errors may occur with more ambitious words. • Punctuation **generally accurate** and **sentence separation correctly marked**, but errors may occur, e.g. with direct speech. • Spelling of **simple vocabulary accurate**; some errors in more ambitious words. • Paragraphs may show **some unity**, although links may be absent or inappropriate. **Appropriateness and Content** • **Relevant**. Some interest aroused, although there may be some lack of originality and/or planning. • Tone **usually appropriate**, although there **may be slips** of register. • Descriptions have satisfactory images, ideas and details which help to create atmosphere. • Arguments make a series of relevant points, with some being developed; linking of ideas may be insecure. • Narratives are straightforward with proper sequencing of sentences.

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Section 2 Language 30 marks		
Band 5	**15–18**	**Writing is sufficiently accurate to communicate meaning, with patches of clear, accurate language.** • **Some variety** of sentence **length** and **structure**, not always for particular purpose. • **Errors** in verb forms and tense consistency **may cause uncertainty in sequence of events** or disturb ease of communication. • Vocabulary **usually adequate to convey intended meaning**; idiom may be uncertain. • Punctuation **used** but not always helpful; **occasional sentence separation errors.** • Spelling of **simple vocabulary accurate**; errors in more difficult words. • Paragraphs **used** but may lack unity or coherence. **Appropriateness and Content** • **Attempt to address topic** but there may be digressions or failures of logic. May lack liveliness and interest. • Tone **may be uneven**. • Descriptions have some detail but may rely too much on narrative. • Arguments have mainly relevant points but may be only partially developed, with some repetition. • Narratives are largely a series of events with only occasional details of character and setting.

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Section 2 Language 30 marks		
Band 4	**11–14**	**Overall meaning never in doubt, but errors sufficiently frequent and serious to hamper precision and distract reader from content.** • **Some simple sentence structures accurate**, but unlikely to sustain accuracy for long. • **Errors** in verb forms and tenses will **sometimes confuse sequence of events**. • Vocabulary **limited**, either too simple or imperfectly understood; some idiomatic errors likely. • **Simple** punctuation **usually accurate**, but there may be frequent sentence separation errors. • Spelling of **simple vocabulary accurate**; **frequent errors** in more difficult words. • Paragraphs **used haphazardly**. **Appropriateness and Content** • **Some relevance**. Some interest. • Tone **may be inconsistent**. • Descriptions are relevant but lack scope or variety. • Arguments make a few points but development is simple and not always logical; some obvious repetition of ideas. • Narratives are simple, everyday or immature.

Section 2 Language 30 marks		
Band 3	**7–10**	**The writing has many serious errors of various kinds of 'single-word' type (i.e. they could be corrected without re-writing the sentence); communication established, although weight of error may cause some 'blurring'.** • Sentences probably **simple** and **repetitive** in structure. • Frequent errors in verb forms and haphazard changes of tense **confuse meaning.** • Vocabulary **conveys meaning** but likely to be **simple** and **imprecise**; significant idiomatic errors. • Spelling **may be inconsistent**. • Punctuation and paragraphing **may be haphazard** or non-existent. **Appropriateness and Content** • **A little** relevance. A little interest. • **Some recognition** of appropriate tone. • In Descriptions the overall picture is unclear. • In Arguments only a few points are discernible and the argument progresses only here and there. • Narratives are very simple and may narrate events indiscriminately.
Band 2	**3–6**	**Sense usually decipherable but some errors will be 'multiple' (i.e. requiring the reader to re-read and re-organise); meaning may be partly hidden by density of linguistic error.** • Unlikely to be more than **a few accurate sentences**, however simple, in the whole essay. **Appropriateness and Content** • **Little relevance** or interest. • Tone **may be inappropriate**. • In Descriptions the overall picture is very unclear. • In Arguments only a very few points are discernible and the argument barely progresses. • Narratives are extremely simple and may narrate events indiscriminately.

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Section 2 Language 30 marks		
Band 1	**1–2**	**Scripts almost entirely or entirely impossible to recognise as pieces of English writing; whole sections make no sense at all.** • Where **occasional patches of relative clarity** are evident, 1 mark should be given. **Appropriateness and Content** • Arguments are rarely relevant and may well be disordered, as are Descriptions and Narratives.
Band 0	**0**	• Insufficient to meet the criteria for Band 1.